Lean Principles

The ideas behind flow, Kanban and continuous improvement: deliver value, remove waste, and keep getting a little better.

Manage Flow · Inspired by Lean Thinking (Womack & Jones) and the Toyota Production System (Taiichi Ohno)

TEAM _____

DATE _____

1 Value

Define value from the customer's point of view: what they would pay for, or miss if it were gone.

ASK

"Who is this for, and what will change for them?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Product Vision Board
- Persona & Journey Map

2 Value stream

Map every step from request to customer, and question each step that adds no value.

ASK

"Which steps would the customer pay for?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Value Stream Map

3 Flow

Make work move smoothly in small batches, without waiting, hand-offs or interruptions.

ASK

"Where does work wait, and why?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Kanban Board Design
- Ageing WIP & SLE

4 Pull

Start new work only when there is capacity and a real need, not because a plan said so.

ASK

"Are we starting more than we finish?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Kanban Cadences
- Buffering & Swarming

5 Perfection

Keep improving in small steps. There is always more waste to remove, so the work never ends.

ASK

"What one small thing could we improve this week?"

TOOLS IN THIS KIT

- Marginal Gains Workshop
- 1% Experiment Canvas

The Eight Wastes

ANYTHING THAT DOESN'T ADD VALUE FOR THE CUSTOMER

WASTE	IN A FACTORY	IN KNOWLEDGE WORK
Transport	Moving parts between places	Hand-offs between people and teams
Inventory	Stock waiting to be used	Partly done work: started, not finished
Motion	People walking and searching	Switching between tasks and tools
Waiting	Idle until the last step finishes	Waiting for approvals, answers, environments
Overproduction	Making more than is ordered	Features nobody asked for or uses
Over-processing	More work than the customer needs	Gold-plating, extra reports, re-doing work
Defects	Faulty parts and rework	Bugs, misunderstood requirements, rework
Unused skills	Ignoring workers' ideas	Not using what people know, or can learn

Taiichi Ohno named the first seven; unused skills was added later. Knowledge-work versions adapted from Mary and Tom Poppendieck, Lean Software Development.

Two Pillars

BOTH, NOT EITHER

Continuous improvement

Small, frequent changes by the people who do the work (kaizen).

Respect for people

Trust people to solve problems, and fix the system, not the person.

Lean Habits

TRY ONE THIS WEEK

Go and see

Watch the work where it happens (gemba).

Stop and fix

When something goes wrong, fix the cause.

Make it visible

Put the work and its problems on a board.

Small batches

Finish small pieces often, not big ones late.

"Which of the eight wastes costs us most, and where do we see it?"

"What would the customer happily pay for, and what wouldn't they?"

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